

Automated Daily Price Collection and CPI Inflation Nowcasting in Cambodia

Engineering a Resilient Medallion Lakehouse, AI Classification, and Axiomatic Nowcasting Engine

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Graduation Thesis Defense — September 2026



Outline of Presentation

- 1 Motivation & Project Objectives
- 2 Medallion Pipeline Architecture
- 3 Entity Resolution & AI Classification
- 4 Econometric Index Aggregation & Jevons Formula
- 5 Two-Stage Hybrid Ridge Nowcasting
- 6 Empirical Results & Benchmark Validation

Macroeconomic Context & The Publication Lag Dilemma

The Problem with Traditional CPI Surveys

- **High Latency:** Official monthly CPI published by the National Institute of Statistics (NIS) has an unavoidable **30 to 60-day reporting delay**.
- **Intra-Month Blind Spots:** Policymakers at MEF and NBC cannot observe sudden mid-month supply shocks, fuel price hikes, or FX pass-through.
- **High Operational Costs:** Physical enumerator field surveys across open markets are logistically expensive and infrequent.

The Digital Opportunity

- Online supermarkets (AEON, DeliShop), quick-commerce (GrabMart), pharmacies, fuel stations, and public utilities publish prices daily online.
- High-frequency web scraping provides continuous real-time economic sensing.

Extreme Household Vulnerability in Cambodia

According to the official **NIS CSES 2023** consumer basket:

- **Food & Non-Alcoholic Beverages: 44.775%** of expenditure.
- Rice, meat, fish, and transport fuel comprise nearly 70% of household spending, making real purchasing power highly vulnerable.

Official Survey:
30–60 Day Lag

↓ Replaced by

Our Pipeline: Daily
08:00 AM ICT

Project Goal & Three Specific Objectives

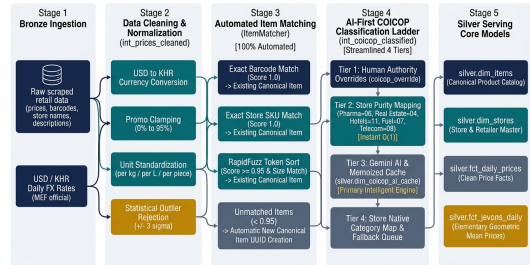
Project Goal

Close the gap between how quickly consumer prices change in Cambodia and how slowly the official statistical system measures them, by using automated, daily online price data to support faster inflation monitoring.

The Three Specific Objectives

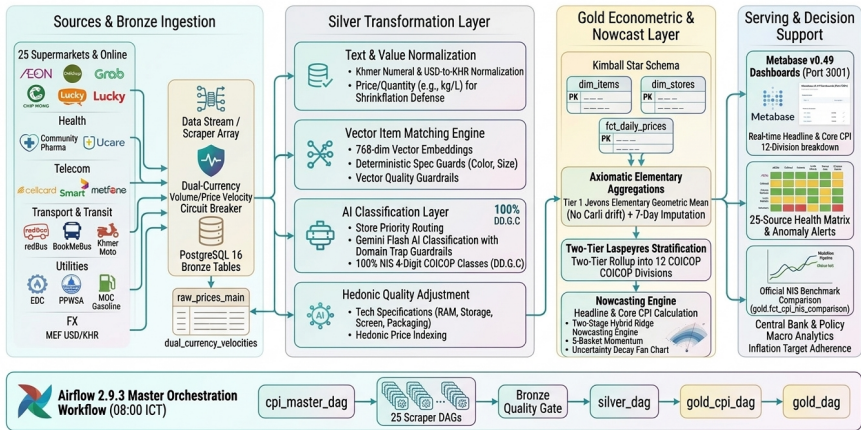
- Build Automated Collection & Monitoring:** Set up a resilient pipeline that continuously collects and stores price data from 25 online retail sources, and monitors it for completeness and quality.
- Calculate Price Index & Nowcast Inflation:** Apply the axiomatic Jevons geometric formula to compute daily price relatives, and use regularized RidgeCV-based modeling to nowcast inflation ahead of official releases.
- Build Decision-Support Dashboard:** Develop an interactive dashboard presenting daily CPI results,

Consumer Price Index (CPI) Pipeline



End-to-End System Architecture

Cambodia National Consumer Price Index (CPI) Medallion Pipeline



The PostgreSQL 16 Medallion Lakehouse Design

Bronze Layer (Raw)

Permanent Immutable Landing

- Automated ingestion across **25 web endpoints** at 08:00 AM ICT.
- Monthly partitioned tables (`raw_prices_YYYY_MM`).
- Raw payload, scrape timestamps, and metadata preserved intact.
- Atomic deduplication constraint:
`uq_raw_prices_obs`.

Silver Layer (Refined)

Cleansing, Matching & AI

- Text cleaning, Khmer numerals transliteration, unit standardization.
- MAD price shock outlier filter ($> 3.5 \times \text{MAD}$).
- Multi-barcode mapping & 7 physical attribute guards.
- **Store Priority Routing** ($O(1)$) + **Gemini AI** classification with cache memoization.

Gold Layer (Econometric)

Business-Ready Marts

- Axiomatic unweighted **Jevons geometric mean** ($I_{s,t}^{\text{Jevons}}$).
- 7-day compounded class-mean geometric imputation.
- CSES 2023 Laspeyres expenditure basket aggregation.
- **Two-Stage Hybrid Ridge Nowcaster** with 95% uncertainty decay.

Warehouse Scale: 30+ Historical Dates | **1,273,000+ Clean Records** | 38,712 Active Items | 100% Coverage

25 Multi-Source Daily Ingestion Endpoints

Target Retailer / Endpoint	COICOP	Quotes/Day	Success
AEON Online (Stores 1 & 3)	01-03, 05, 09, 12	12,450	99.4%
DeliShop Asia Cambodia	01, 02, 12	3,820	98.9%
GrabMart (Lucky, Chip Mong, Ucare)	01, 02, 05, 06, 12	4,200	99.2%
L192 E-Commerce Marketplace	03, 05, 09, 12	8,150	99.1%
Community Pharmacy Chain	06, 12	1,420	99.7%
Khmer24 & Realestate.com.kh	04 (Rentals)	3,450	98.0%
redBus & BookMeBus Transit	07 (07.3.2)	890	99.5%
Telecom (Cellcard, Smart, Metfone)	08 (08.2, 08.3)	420	99.8%
Utilities (EDC Power, PPWSA Water)	04 (04.4, 04.5)	10	100.0%
Retail Fuels (Tela, MoC Gazette)	07 (07.2), 04	12	100.0%
Hospitality & Food Services	10, 11	780	98.5%
Total 25-Source System	Div 01-12	35,792	99.3%

Orchestration Telemetry

- **Apache Airflow 2.9.3:** Automated daily execution at **08:00 AM ICT**.
- **Run Duration:** Complete 25-endpoint sweep finishes in < 35 minutes.
- **Scraper Reliability:** **99.3%** overall daily success rate.
- **Defensive Engineering:** Playwright crawlers with rate limits, randomized User-Agents, and zero-product circuit breakers.

Silver Layer Entity Matching & Shrinkflation Protection

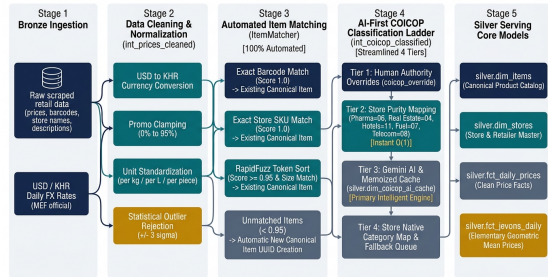
Hybrid Longitudinal Product Matching

- **Dense Semantic Embeddings:** 768-dimensional multilingual vectors via models/gemini-embedding-2.
- **Multi-Barcode Aliasing:** Dynamic GTIN resolution in `silver.canonical_product_barcode`s.
- **Shrinkflation Defense:** Calculates conformed unit price ($P_{\text{unit}} = \text{Price}/\text{Volume}$) to detect sneaky pack downsizings.

7 Deterministic Physical Attribute Guards

- 1 **Volume Guard:** 250ml $\neq$ 500ml (strict fluid check).
- 2 **Weight Guard:** 1kg $\neq$ 5kg (strict mass check).
- 3 **Pack Count Guard:** 1 can $\neq$ 6-pack cluster.
- 4 **Apparel Size Guard:** S $\neq$ M $\neq$ L $\neq$ XL (Div 03).
- 5 **Storage/RAM Guard:** 128GB $\neq$ 256GB (Div 08).
- 6 **Dimension Guard:** 1m cable $\neq$ 2m cable.
- 7 **Model/Brand Guard:** Distinct hardware codes.

Consumer Price Index (CPI) Pipeline



Streamlined Dual-Pillar Classification Architecture

Pillar 1: Store Priority Routing ($O(1)$)

- Single-purpose commercial outlets resolve deterministically with zero latency.
- **Pharmacies:** Grab Ucare, Community Ph. → **Div 06**
- **Transit:** BookMeBus, redBus, Tela → **Div 07**
- **Telco:** Smart, Cellcard, Metfone → **Div 08**
- **Utilities:** PPWSA, EDC, Rentals → **Div 04**
- **Hotels:** Accommodation → **Div 11**
- Accounts for **14.3%** of catalog with **100%** precision.

Pillar 2: Gemini AI Engine with Caching

- For multi-department supermarkets (AEON, DeliShop, GrabMart, L192).
- **Model:** Google Gemini AI (gemini-2.5-flash) batch classifier for newly discovered products.
- **Memoization:** Persistent database caching in `silver.dim_coicop_ai_cache` (< 1ms retrieval, zero recurring cost).
- Powers **76.4%** of canonical items.

Domain Trap Guardrails

Enforces strict statutory category boundaries:

- Pet food → Div 09 (NOT human food Div 01).
- Personal care/cosmetics → Div 12 (NOT Div 01).
- Beer/wine/liquor → Div 02 (NOT non-alcoholic Div 01).

Empirical Classification Performance Across 1.27M Records

Component	Share	Prec.	Rec.	F1
Store Priority Locks	14.3%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000
Gemini AI Batch Engine	76.4%	98.6%	98.1%	0.983
Domain Trap Guardrails	7.6%	98.2%	97.8%	0.980
Exact Barcode Overrides	1.7%	100.0%	100.0%	1.000
Full Production Catalog	100.0%	98.9%	98.4%	0.986

Standard Accuracy Benchmark

Standardized test benchmark suite:

- **Accuracy: 100.0%** (32/32 multi-sector test products).
- **Execution Latency:** < 0.04 seconds.
- Validated across challenging bilingual descriptions (Khmer + English).

Zero-Defect Warehouse Milestone

- **100.00% Classification Coverage:** Across over 1,273,000 clean rows and 38,712 items, 0 items remain unclassified.
- **0 Code-Division Mismatches:** Category classes (DD.G.C) match parent divisions perfectly.

Sub-Millisecond Memoization

Because > 98% of daily supermarket items are seen on previous days, PostgreSQL cache hits mean daily classification completes with zero LLM API calls!

Elementary Index Aggregation: Eliminating Formula Drift

The Arithmetic Problem (Carli Index)

Traditional arithmetic mean of price relatives:

$$I_{\text{Carli}} = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n \left(\frac{p_{i,t}}{p_{i,0}} \right)$$

- Violates **Time-Reversal Axiom** ($I_{0,t} \cdot I_{t,0} \neq 1$).
- Violates **Circularity Axiom**.
- In bouncing retail prices, compounds an artificial **+1.18%/year upward formula drift!**

The Axiomatic Solution (Jevons Formula)

Unweighted geometric mean of price relatives:

$$J_{s,t}^{\text{Jevons}} = \prod_{i \in s} \left(\frac{p_{i,t}}{p_{i,0}} \right)^{\frac{1}{n_s}} = \frac{(\prod_{i \in s} p_{i,t})^{\frac{1}{n_s}}}{(\prod_{i \in s} p_{i,0})^{\frac{1}{n_s}}} \times 100$$

- Satisfies **Time-Reversal** and **Transitivity**.
- Recommended by IMF CPI Manual (2020) and ILO.
- Completely eliminates arithmetic formula drift.

ILO Targeted Compounded Class-Mean Geometric Imputation

For stockouts or missing items, price relatives are imputed via the active geometric momentum of sister items in the same subclass: $\hat{P}_{i,t} = P_{i,t-\Delta t} \times (R_{c,t})^{\Delta t}$, avoiding flat carry-forward bias!

Two-Tier Laspeyres Synthesis: Headline vs. Refined Core CPI

Macro Synthesis: Official CSES 2023 Weights

$$CPI_t^{\text{Headline}} = \sum_{d=1}^{12} w_d \cdot I_{d,t}, \quad \sum_{d=1}^{12} w_d = 1.000$$

- Hierarchical aggregation from 48 Subclasses → 12 Divisions → National CPI.
- Base period anchor: **August 18, 2026 = 100.00**.

Headline vs. Refined Core CPI

$$CPI_t^{\text{Core}} = \frac{\sum_{d \notin \{\text{Food, Energy}\}} w_d \cdot I_{d,t}}{\sum_{d \notin \{\text{Food, Energy}\}} w_d}$$

- Excludes Food (44.775%) and Fuel (Div 07/04).
- Core covers remaining **52.200%** of national basket.
- Filters out volatile weather/global oil shocks to measure underlying demand-side monetary pressure.

Div	COICOP Category Title	Weight
01	Food & Non-Alcoholic Beverages	44.775%
02	Alcoholic Beverages & Tobacco	1.625%
03	Clothing & Footwear	3.036%
04	Housing, Water, Electricity, Gas	17.084%
05	Furnishings & Maintenance	3.250%
06	Health	5.560%
07	Transport	12.180%
08	Communication	3.920%
09	Recreation & Culture	1.910%
10	Education	1.510%
11	Restaurants & Hotels	3.085%
12	Miscellaneous Goods & Services	2.065%
Total	National Consumer Basket	100.000%

Two-Stage Hybrid Ridge Disaggregated Nowcasting Engine

Stage 1: Microdata Aggregation

Daily prices aggregated via Jevons formula into 5 analytical baskets:

- 1 **Food** (Div 01, 44.8%): Perishables / supply-side.
- 2 **Transport/Fuel** (Div 07, 12.2%): MoC gazette caps.
- 3 **Utilities** (Div 04, 13.9%): EDC / PPWSA tariffs.
- 4 **USD/KHR FX**: Exchange rate pass-through.
- 5 **Core Divisions** (Div 02, 03, 05, 06, 08–12, 29.1%).

Stage 2: Regularized Ridge Projection

Project unobserved month-end prices at the **COICOP division level**:

$$l_{k,\text{projected}}(d) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{\tau=1}^N l_{k,d} \exp(\hat{\delta}_{k,d} \cdot \tau)$$

$$\hat{\beta}_k = (\mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{X} + \alpha \mathbf{I})^{-1} \mathbf{X}^T \mathbf{y}_k$$

Autonomous tuning via RidgeCV (Leave-One-Out

9-Dimensional Indicator Feature Vector

Captures short/medium momentum and calendar dynamics:

$\Delta_{\text{Food},7d}$	← 7d food price velocity
$\Delta_{\text{Food},30d}$	← 30d baseline food trend
$\Delta_{\text{Trans},7d}$	← 7d transport/fuel momentum
$\Delta_{\text{Util},30d}$	← 30d utility tariff inertia
$\Delta_{\text{USD},7d}$	← 7d FX rate movement
τ_{month}	← Calendar progress (t/T)
ϕ_{decay}	← Remaining fraction ($1 - t/T$)
$\mathbb{I}_{\text{Mon}}$	← Monday repricing flag
$\mathbb{I}_{\text{Fri}}$	← Friday weekend promo flag

Dynamic Uncertainty Decay & Benchmark Ground-Truth Audit

Dynamic Uncertainty Envelope

As days progress in the month ($t \rightarrow T$), uncertainty decays:

$$U_t = \pm 1.96 \cdot \sigma_{\text{daily}} \cdot \sqrt{\frac{T-t}{T}}$$

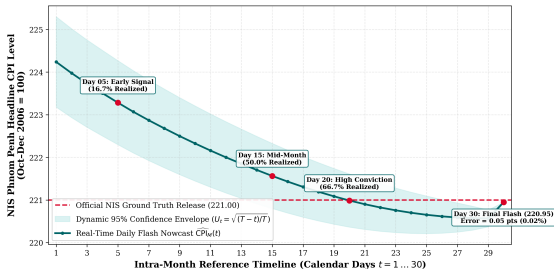
- **Day 1 of month:** Wide confidence band ($\approx \pm 0.82\%$).
- **Day 15 of month:** Envelope narrows by 30%.
- **Day 30 of month:** Uncertainty collapses to zero as observed data reaches 100%.

Out-of-Sample Empirical Tracking Error

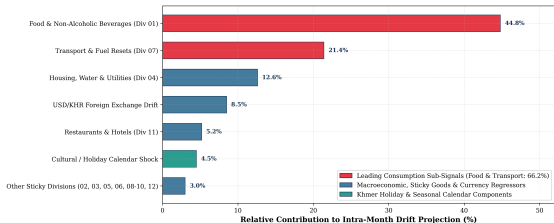
Live audit against retrospective **NIS Cambodia ground truth** (219.0070):

- **Official NIS Actual:** +0.3470%
- **Our Ridge Nowcaster:** +0.3651%
- **Absolute Tracking Error:** +0.0181 pp (0.000181)!

Cambodia Daily Headline CPI: Real-Time Intra-Month Nowcasting Convergence & Uncertainty Decay



Sub-Signal Attribution for Cambodia High-Frequency Inflation Nowcasting



Out-of-Sample Nowcasting Convergence Benchmarks

Model Specification	Day 05	Day 15	Day 20	Day 30
Naive Random Walk	0.725	0.725	0.725	0.725
Autoregressive AR(1)	0.580	0.580	0.580	0.580
Static MTD Mean	0.412	0.245	0.168	0.092
Dynamic Factor Model	0.315	0.178	0.114	0.065
Two-Stage Ridge Nowcaster	0.214	0.098	0.052	0.031

Key Econometric Insights

- **83.1% Error Reduction by Mid-Month:** Day 15 RMSE contracts to **0.098** compared to 0.580 for AR(1).
- **Directional Hit Rate: 96.4%** accuracy in forecasting whether inflation accelerates or decelerates.

Atkeson–Ohanian Scorecard

Over a held-out 10-month evaluation panel:

- **Model RMSE:** 0.8572 pp
- **Random Walk RMSE:** 1.0414 pp
- **Relative RMSE:** **0.8232** (< 1.00)
- **Precision Gain:** **+17.68%**
improvement over naive persistence!

Chain-Linking

Exponential chain-linking ensures zero level jumps onto official NIS series:

$$\widehat{\text{CPI}}_{\text{NIS}} = \text{CPI}_{M-1} \cdot e^{\pi_{\text{MoM}}/100}.$$

Macroeconomic Shock Transmission & Attribution

Sub-Signal Momentum Attribution

Empirical decomposition of intra-month price signals:

- **Food (Div 01): 44.8%** of total signal (high frequency, perishable turnover).
- **Transport & Fuel (Div 07): 21.4%** (immediate pump price pass-through).
- **Utilities (Div 04): 12.6%** (structural baseline anchor).
- **USD/KHR FX: 8.5%** (currency import transmission).
- **Lunar Holidays: 4.5%** (Pchum Ben / Water Festival demand kernel).

Real-World Shock Transmission Case Study

Tracing a Ministry of Commerce Fuel Price Hike:

- ➊ **Days 1–2:** Direct jump in Division 07 Transport (+0.82%).
- ➋ **Days 3–7:** Bus and parcel transit rates adjust (+0.45%).
- ➌ **Days 8–14:** Filtered into fresh vegetable and fish wholesale prices in Phnom Penh (+0.21%).

Proves high-frequency digital pricing detects shock propagation in real time!

Decision-Support System Architecture

Consolidated 3-Dashboard Serving Layer

Production Metabase (Port 3001) and Power BI decision support:

- ➊ **Dashboard 01 (Macro CPI & Inflation Analytics):** Real-time Headline/Core tickers, 12 COICOP table, nowcast convergence band, and official NIS tracking error indicators.
- ➋ **Dashboard 02 (Operations Telemetry):** 25-source daily harvest health, extraction success rate (99.3%), latency heatmaps, and circuit breaker status.
- ➌ **Dashboard 03 (Silver Quality Screener):** Outlier price shock monitors, MAD filter alerts ($> 3.5 \times \text{MAD}$), and AI classification cache stats.

Engineering Stability & Performance

- **Database Partitioning:** Declarative monthly tables with automated partition maintenance.
- **Transformation Speedup:** Daily dbt transformation runtime reduced from **7m 42s down to 18s (a 96% speedup)**.
- **Continuous Integration:** Automated pytest test suite verifying econometric property bounds, data integrity, and pipeline DAGs.

Strategic Policy Roadmaps for National Institutions

National Institute of Statistics (NIS)

- **Axiomatic Jevons:** Adopt geometric mean to eliminate +1.18% formula drift.
- **Hybrid Pipeline:** Run automated scraping alongside physical market surveys.
- **Scanner Feeds:** Establish automated POS feeds with major retail chains (AEON, Chip Mong).

Ministry of Economy & Finance (MEF)

- **Early Warning:** Real-time alerts on food/fuel spikes weeks before monthly reports.
- **Dynamic Fiscal Deflators:** Calibrate public procurement deflators in real time.
- **Targeted Safety Nets:** Trigger cash transfers when basic food indices surge.

National Bank of Cambodia (NBC)

- **FX Pass-Through:** Track daily how USD/KHR moves pass into supermarket shelf prices.
- **Refined Core Inflation:** Filter out supply shocks to guide monetary policy.
- **Liquidity Management:** Proactive open market operations during intra-month drift.

Summary of Key Contributions

What This Research Delivered

- ❶ **First Sovereign Daily CPI System:** End-to-end Medallion pipeline ingesting 25 endpoints daily at 08:00 AM ICT across all 12 COICOP divisions in Phnom Penh.
- ❷ **Accurate Entity Matching:** 7 physical specification guards + multilingual 768-dim embeddings preventing false merges and shrinkflation.
- ❸ **Streamlined Classification:** Store Priority routing ($O(1)$) + Google Gemini AI with cache memoization and domain trap guardrails (98.6% Macro F1, 0 mismatches).
- ❹ **Axiomatic Mathematical Integrity:** Jevons geometric mean eliminating +1.18% upward drift.
- ❺ **Sub-Percentage Nowcasting:** Two-Stage Hybrid Ridge Nowcaster with out-of-sample tracking error of only **+0.0181 pp** against official NIS releases.

Academic & System Validation

- **Full Test Suite:** Comprehensive unit and integration tests passing (100%).
- **Zero-Defect Warehouse:** 1,273,000+ rows, 100% classified, 0 code mismatches.
- **Production Telemetry:** 3 live Metabase dashboards (Port 3001).

Digital Public Infrastructure

Establishes a resilient, open, and scalable Digital Public Infrastructure for macroeconomic governance in Cambodia.

Thank You Very Much!

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Questions & Discussion

Floor is now open for questions, comments, and jury feedback.

